

PRETZELS

MAKES ABOUT EIGHTEEN PRETZELS.

I'm very particular about pretzels. For one thing, I like them with both thick and thin sections; this prevents pretzel boredom. The crust should have a nice snap when you bite in, and the interior shouldn't be too doughy.

The instructions for shaping these pretzels may seem complicated when you first read them, but with a little practice it will all make sense.

These pretzels are dipped in a food-grade lye to give them extra color and a pretzel-like flavor, something you won't get with the baking soda dips that many other recipes call for. Of course, lye is a bit tricky to work with. First, you have to be sure you buy edible lye, *not* the stuff to clear drains. Many pharmacies carry the right type. And it's essential that you wear rubber gloves as you work. If you want to be supercautious, you might even wear eye goggles. If all this makes you nervous, you can brush the pretzels with an egg wash. They won't have the same flavor, but they will have a nice golden shine.

Note: Lye can be reused as long as it's kept covered, although it gets weaker with time. If your pretzels don't come out as dark as they should, it's probably time to buy new lye.

TWO-DAY BREAD—FIRST DAY

HAVE READY:

Mixing bowl

Mixer with attachable dough hook, optional

Long-stemmed, instant-read cooking thermometer

Dough cutter

Proofing cloth

Spray bottle, filled with water

1 or 2 parchment-lined (or Magic Baking Sheet-lined) baking sheets plus an additional baking sheet for dipping, optional

1 or 2 plastic trash can liners

6 ounces (about $\frac{3}{4}$ cup) cool water, 70 degrees F

9 ounces (about 1 cup) White Starter

1 pound 4 ounces (about 5 cups) unbleached white bread flour, plus extra for dusting
1 tablespoon barley malt syrup
2 teaspoons fine sea salt

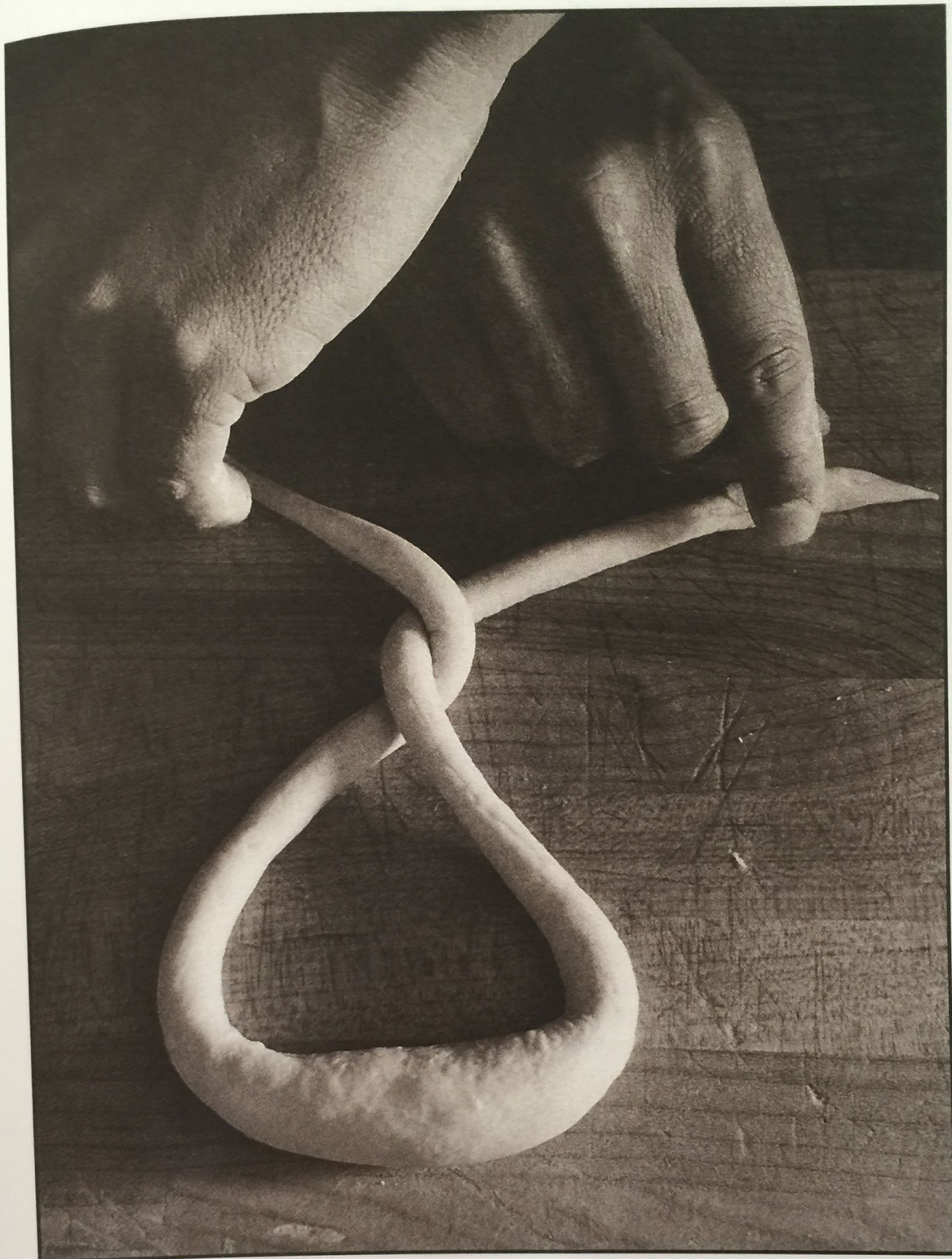
Place water, White Starter, flour, malt syrup, and salt in the bowl of a mixer fitted with a dough hook. Mix on low speed for 1 to 2 minutes to combine ingredients. (The dough may also be mixed by hand; see basic instructions on page 42.) Turn the mixer up to medium and mix until the dough is smooth, elastic, and firm and reaches an internal temperature of 75 to 76 degrees F, about 8 minutes.

Turn the dough out onto an unfloured work surface and knead it for a few minutes by hand. Cut the dough with a dough cutter into eighteen 3-ounce pieces. Tuck under the edges of each piece, cover them with a cloth, and let the dough rest for 45 minutes.

Working with one piece of dough at a time and keeping the rest covered, shape a rope 9 inches long by placing one hand on top of the other, palms down, in the center of the dough and rolling it into a cylinder shape. Avoid using flour. If there is not enough friction between the dough and the work surface, spritz the work surface lightly with water from a spray bottle. As the rope begins to stretch, uncross your hands and continue rolling with light, even pressure, moving your hands slowly to the ends of the rope without tapering the ends. Leaving a center belly 3 inches long, place the palms of your hands on each side of the belly, and roll and stretch again to elongate the cylinder to about 20 inches. Lay your hands on top of each end and taper the ends by alternately rolling each one toward and away from you (think of the arm motions of a cross-country skier).

Cross your arms and grab opposite ends of the dough by pinching it between your thumbs and forefingers. Without letting go of the dough, uncross your arms and cross the ends of the dough to make a twist with a 4-inch tail on each side. Lift the left end and press it firmly into the left top of the belly just where the belly begins to taper, leaving a $\frac{1}{4}$ -inch overhang. Repeat with the right end.

Transfer the pretzel to a parchment-lined baking sheet. Adjust shape if necessary. Repeat this shape with the remaining pieces of dough, placing them 2 inches apart on the baking sheet. Cover the pretzels with a cloth and allow them to sit at room temperature just until they begin to show signs of movement, about 1 hour.



*F*ORMING A PRETZEL:

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Place each baking sheet into a plastic trash can liner and refrigerate for 12 to 24 hours.

SECOND DAY

HAVE READY:

Nonreactive mixing bowl (plastic or ceramic)

Wooden spoon

Rubber gloves

Eye goggles, optional

Baking sheets

Cooling rack

1 quart water

1 ounce (1 tablespoon) food-grade lye or 2 egg yolks mixed with a teaspoon of water

Pastry brush, optional

Vegetable oil

Coarse sea salt for sprinkling

Preheat the oven to 400 degrees F 1 hour before baking. Be sure the oven racks are placed well apart to allow plenty of air circulation.

If you are going to dip the pretzels in a lye solution, they need to be dipped as soon as they are removed from the refrigerator. Otherwise they will lose their shape and be too difficult to dip. Have plenty of counter space available to set up a dipping and draining assembly line.

Mix water and lye in a plastic or ceramic (nonreactive) mixing bowl and stir with a wooden spoon to combine. Set the solution aside. Place a cooling rack on top of a baking sheet and set it next to the lye solution.

Lightly oil another 1 or 2 baking sheets and set these next to the first baking sheet.

Remove the dough from the refrigerator and take off the plastic trash can liner. Wearing rubber gloves, and goggles if desired, dip the pretzels one at a time in the lye solution for 15 to 30 seconds. Transfer each pretzel to the cooling rack and allow it to drain before putting it on the oil-coated baking sheet. Dip and drain the remaining pretzels, placing them on the baking sheet about 2 inches apart.

If you are going to use an egg wash, simply remove the dough from the refrigerator, take off the plastic wrap, and brush the pretzels with the egg wash. (It is not necessary to bake the pretzels on an oiled baking sheet.)

After all the pretzels have been dipped or brushed with egg, sprinkle each with a large pinch of sea salt. The pretzels must be baked immediately after they have been topped with salt or the salt will dissolve.

Place the pretzels in the oven and bake for 20 to 25 minutes. It may be necessary to rotate the baking sheets to ensure even baking.

The pretzels are done when they turn a rich, mahogany brown. 